

CoARA Action Plan

SLU's commitment

In February 2024, SLU joined CoARA and signed the agreement with principles and commitments concerning the assessment of research. By signing the CoARA agreement SLU is committed to review and revise the way we assess research and researchers, by recognising diverse outputs, practices and activities that maximise the quality and impact of research. The process will be carried out in close dialogue with the academic community as well as with relevant support functions.

The decision to join CoARA was preceded by discussions in the Vice-Chancellor's Management Council and with the International Advisory Board, both taking a positive stance to the CoARA mission. An analysis on how SLU's relevant governing documents align with CoARA's principles was carried out, confirming that SLU's Appointment procedures, Quality assurance system and Policies for Open science and Data management already harmonize with the principles within CoARA. In addition, SLU is certified within the framework HR for Excellence in Research. As a result, SLU has many essential parts of the CoARA principles already in place. In the coming years, SLU will analyse how we can continue to develop our processes in line with CoARA and how we can support a cultural shift within research assessment.

Implementing CoARA at SLU

Reforming research assessment by promoting a diversification of career paths and merits requires continuous work and reflection, both at the university level and at national and international level. From SLU's perspective, it is important to join forces and seek harmonisation with other universities, research funders and other relevant authorities in the CoARA transition.

In addition to the specific actions that SLU plans to undertake, SLU will continuously:

- engage in the Swedish National Chapter for CoARA,
- take and give inspiration within the wider CoARA community,

- raise awareness and dialogue around the CoARA commitments with the SLU academic community as well as in our support functions,
- ensure that the CoARA implementation promotes and supports research quality and impact at SLU in a way that harmonises with our mission and strategy
- regularly review and, if needed, revise the Activity Plan.

Timeline

2024: Establishing and anchoring the CoARA initiative in the organisation

- Drawing up the SLU CoARA Action plan is the focus during this first year. The comparison between SLU's governing documents for quality assurance, data management and appointment procedures with the agreement is an important starting point.
- The pro-vice-chancellor for international relations has been appointed to lead a working group to develop the action plan. The group consists of operational support from the SLU library, the division of planning and the HR division.
- The working group discusses CoARA with different reference groups, such as the appointment boards of the faculties, senior researchers and junior faculty groups. At this stage, the reference groups are introduced to the CoARA work and contribute with their perspectives and experiences.
- A wider awareness of and information about CoARA is spread through news posts on the employee website.

2025-2026: Concretising and implementing activities

- In the areas that SLU points out as priorities in the CoARA context (see focus areas below), more concrete activities are initiated, and responsibilities are assigned for each effort or activity.
- Implementation of activities begins.
- During this period, preparations are made for SLU's recurring external evaluation of research "Quality and Impact" to be carried out during 2027. Adapting the evaluation to the CoARA principles is one of the major measures during SLU's first 5-year period as CoARA members. Dialogues

will be held with Heads of Departments, with the aim of co-creating the Quality and Impact assessment in a way beneficial to the departments.

2027: *Continued implementation, follow-up and refinement of activities*

- Based on feedback from daily operations, or in response to developments in the HEI sector, we evaluate and refine reformed procedures or activities when required.
- The “Quality and Impact” assessment is carried out at the university with external reviewers and internal self-evaluations. We expect to gain experience on how the CoARA principles can be used in practice when assessing research at the organizational level.

2028: *Evaluation, reporting and looking ahead*

- We evaluate and report results and reflections from the first 5-year period to the CoARA consortium.
- Based on the outcome of activities during the first period, the status within SLU and in the HEI sector, we consider possibilities for future activities to support the CoARA mission.

Focus areas at SLU related to the CoARA commitments

Under the guidance of and with support from SLU’s CoARA working group, relevant university bodies will review and, if necessary or desirable, revise policies and routines in relation to the CoARA commitments. SLU has decided to focus the work around the following areas: assessment of merits and qualifications, quality assurance processes, allocation of resources, and communication efforts. The lists below highlight topics that will be relevant to address within each focus area.

Assessment of merits and qualifications

- Employment and promotion
- Competence level
- Doctoral degree
- Merit value of collaboration
- Merit value of academic citizenship and leadership
- Merit value of collaborations and interdisciplinarity
- Developing bibliometric tools with a CoARA perspective
- Exploring the use of narrative CV:s

Quality assurance processes

- Developing the "Quality and Impact 2027" assessment
- Evaluating the "Quality and Impact 2027" assessment as an implementation of CoARA
- Quality areas and standards within the SLU Quality Assurance system (practices and activities)

Allocation of resources

- Performance-based internal allocation of funds
- Assessment within internal strategic efforts (co-financing principles, career grants, tenure positions, nominations etc)

Communication efforts

- Discussing CoARA with relevant reference groups
- Outreach to a wider academic community, for example by web-based CoARA information
- Sharing of experiences and good practice within the National Chapter and relevant working groups
- Dialogues about CoARA implementation with Heads of Departments, in general terms and specifically in the development of the Quality and Impact 2027 assessment.

The quality of research and benefit for daily operations at our departments will be the guiding principles. There is also a need for aligning the CoARA implementation with the actions SLU takes within the framework HR Excellens for Research. In general, continuous anchoring processes and sharing of experiences within the community is essential for a gradual cultural shift in research assessment.